



Grit hit: Ekta Bhyan, a club thrower in the F51 bracket, registered a season's best effort of 20.12m to win gold in the women's F51 class at the World Para Athletics Championships in Kobe, Japan. GETTYIMAGES

disability class. Then 41, Vinod was put under review by a classification panel, which later decided that he was ineligible to compete in the F52 class — a section where athletes compete in a seated position, either in a wheelchair or a throwing chair, due to impaired muscle power, restricted range of movement, limb deficiency, or leg length difference.

The Board of Appeal of Classification (BAC), an independent body, then banned him for intentionally misrepresenting his abilities in classification, suspending him from participation in para athletics for two years.

This isn't a rare occurrence.

Athlete classification is the defining foundation of para sports, as that's where the playing field is levelled. There are instances where athletes are mistakenly classified into the wrong classes. This could happen because of a change in ability/function (improvement or decline) over time. There are times when athletes purposefully exaggerate their disabilities too. The latter has been decried heavily with each passing Paralympic cycle, likened to how immoral and unsportsmanlike doping is.

Evolving yet sacrosanct

At the heart of it all lies the process of classification itself and awareness among athletes and classifiers alike.

"It's fairly common for young and new athletes to see back-and-forth with their classification, but it shouldn't be the case for established athletes who have competed in a bunch of major events," Ekta added.

Manish Rana, Director of Sports Development and Performance with

the PCI, underlines that classification from an administrative perspective is a diverse exercise. Disciplines like athletics and swimming have multiple subclasses, while others like powerlifting or judo have one or two classes.

"There is a minimum impairment criterion, and classifiers look at underlying health conditions that lead to permanent disability, which then makes them eligible to play certain sports. For example, someone could lose a digit. That is technically a disability, but it doesn't mean they might qualify for para sports," Rana said.

Classifications can only be done in IPC-approved events, which is why Indians seek out Grand Prix events or World Championships to get this out of the way. It comes with massive costs, monetary and otherwise. The fact that nations only get a certain number of slots makes that process more competitive.

"We have to make tough choices based on how many slots we're allowed. Priority is given to